

How to solve cryptic clue

learn crossword (vol. 1)



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Introduction

Welcome to the Cryptic Crossword Preparation Guide

Congratulations on taking the first step toward mastering cryptic crosswords.

Unlike ordinary crosswords, cryptic crosswords are not solved by guessing. Every clue follows a logical pattern and contains hidden techniques. Once you understand these techniques, even difficult clues become much easier to solve.

This guide has been created for students preparing for cryptic crossword competitions. Its purpose is not to make you memorize answers, but to teach you how to think like a cryptic crossword solver.

Inside this guide you will learn

- The most important cryptic clue types.
- Common indicator words used in clues.
- Step-by-step solutions with explanations.
- Practice questions to improve speed and accuracy.
- Tips and strategies for solving clues under time pressure.

To get the best results, do not skip directly to the answers. First, try solving each clue on your own. Then compare your approach with the explanation. Over time, you will start recognizing clue patterns automatically.

Remember, cryptic crosswords reward logic, observation, and practice—not luck.

Let's begin the journey toward becoming a confident cryptic crossword solver.

Chapter: 01

Cryptic Crossword Basics.



What is a Cryptic Crossword?

A cryptic crossword is a special type of crossword puzzle in which every clue is designed as a word puzzle. Unlike ordinary crosswords, the answer is not found by simply knowing the meaning of the clue. Instead, each clue contains a hidden method that leads you to the correct answer.

Every cryptic clue is carefully written so that it can be solved using logic, clue-solving techniques, and vocabulary—not by guessing.

Difference between normal Crossword and cryptic crossword:

Normal Crossword	Cryptic Crossword
Clues are direct.	Clues contain hidden wordplay.
Tests vocabulary.	Tests logic, vocabulary, and pattern recognition.
Guessing may work.	Guessing rarely works.
It usually has one meaning.	Contains both a definition and wordplay.

Parts of a Cryptic Clue:



A cryptic clue usually has two parts:

1. Definition -

A direct meaning of the answer. It is usually found at the beginning or the end of the clue.

2. Wordplay -

A hidden instruction that tells you how to build or discover the answer. The wordplay may involve an anagram, hidden word, reversal, charade, homophone, container, deletion, or another cryptic technique.

Important:

Both the definition and the wordplay must lead to the same answer.

Example:

Clue: Way mixed PETS (4)

DOGS

STEP

STEW

WAX

Answer: STEP

Solution

- Definition: Way → STEP
- Indicator Word: Mixed
- Wordplay: Rearrange the letters of PETS
- PETS → STEP

Since STEP satisfies both the definition and the wordplay, it is the correct answer.

Why Learn Cryptic Crossword Techniques?

Learning clue-solving techniques will help you:

- Solve clues faster and more accurately.
- Recognize common clue patterns.
- Avoid random guessing.
- Improve logical thinking and vocabulary.
- Build confidence in competitions.
- Increase your solving speed under time pressure.

The Golden Rules

1. Every cryptic clue contains a definition.
2. Always look for indicator words.
3. Pay attention to the answer length shown in brackets.
4. Do not guess the answer—solve it logically.
5. Make sure both the definition and the wordplay match the same answer.

Key Takeaway

Cryptic crosswords are puzzles of logic. Once you understand the clue types and indicator words, solving even difficult clues becomes much easier. Practice regularly, think carefully, and trust the clue's logic rather than guessing.

The next chapter introduces the most important clue types used in cryptic crosswords.

Chapter: 02

Understanding cryptic clue types



Why Are Clue Types Important?

Before solving any cryptic clue, ask yourself one simple question:

"What type of clue is this?"

Almost every cryptic clue belongs to a specific clue type. Once you identify the clue type, you already know how the answer is hidden.

For example:

- If you see mixed, you should think of an Anagram.
- If you see inside, you should look for a Hidden Word or Container clue.

- If you see back, you should check for a Reversal clue.

Recognizing clue types is the first step toward becoming a skilled cryptic crossword solver.

Major Cryptic Clue Types

Clue Type	What You Need to Do	Common Indicator Words
 Anagram	Rearrange letters to form a new word.	mixed, confused, broken, wild
 Hidden Word	Find the answer hidden inside the clue.	in, inside, among, hidden
 Charade	Join two or more words or abbreviations.	with, plus, after, before
 Container	Put one word inside another.	in, around, holding, containing
 Reversal	Read the letters backwards.	back, returned, reversed
 Deletion	Remove one or more letters.	without, losing, dropping
 Homophone	Find a word that sounds the same.	heard, reportedly, we hear
 Initial Letters	Take the first letters of words.	first, initially, at first
 Final Letters	Take the last letters of words.	finally, at the end
 Odd / Even Letters	Select alternate letters.	odd, even, alternate
 Double Definition	Two different meanings give the same answer.	Usually no indicator
 Cryptic Definition	The whole clue cleverly describes the answer.	Usually no indicator

The Three-Step Solving Method

Whenever you solve a cryptic clue, follow these three steps:

Step 1 – Find the Indicator Word

Look for words that tell you what operation to perform.

Step 2 – Identify the Clue Type

Decide whether it is an Anagram, Hidden Word, Charade, Reversal, or another clue type.

Step 3 – Solve the Clue

Apply the correct solving technique and check whether the answer matches both the definition and the wordplay.

Common Mistakes Made by Beginners

-  **Guessing the answer without identifying clue type.**
-  **Ignoring indicator words.**

- ✗ Forgetting to check the answer length.**
- ✗ Choosing a word that matches the definition but not the wordplay.**

Key Takeaways

- ✓ Every cryptic clue belongs to a clue type.**
- ✓ Indicator words help you identify the clue type.**
- ✓ Always solve the clue logically—never guess.**
- ✓ Make sure both the definition and the wordplay point to the same answer.**

In the next chapter, we will study each cryptic clue type in detail, including its definition, common indicator words, solved examples, practice questions, and expert tips for identifying and solving it accurately.

Chapter: 03

Anagram Clue



What is an Anagram Clue?

An Anagram Clue is one of the most common and easiest clue types in cryptic crosswords. In this type of clue, the letters of a word or phrase are rearranged to form the correct answer.

To help the solver recognize an anagram, the clue usually contains an indicator word that suggests the letters should be mixed, changed, or rearranged.

Example:

ANIMAL → MANALI

The letters remain the same; only their order changes.

How to Identify an Anagram Clue

When solving a cryptic clue, look for words that suggest mixing, changing, or rearranging letters. These words are known as Anagram Indicators.

Common Anagram Indicators

Mixed

Wild

Prepared

Confused

Broken

Strange

Crazy

Jumbled

Twisted

Rearranged

Altered

Disorderly

Changed

Scrambled

Disturbed

Tip: An indicator usually appears immediately before or after the letters that need to be rearranged.

How to Solve an Anagram Clue

Follow these four simple steps:

Step 1: Find the Anagram Indicator.

Step 2: Identify the word or phrase whose letters must be rearranged.

Step 3: Rearrange the letters to form a meaningful word.

Step 4: Verify that the new word matches both the definition and the required answer length.

Solved Example 1

Clue: Wild animal in hill station

Shimla

Manali

Nainital

Srinagar

Step-by-Step Solution

Step 1 – Find the Indicator

The word Wild is the anagram indicator.

Step 2 – Identify the Letters

The letters to be rearranged are ANIMAL.

Step 3 – Rearrange the Letters

ANIMAL → MANALI

Step 4 – Verify the Definition

The definition is "hill station." Manali is a famous hill station.

Final Answer: MANALI 

Solved Example 2

Clue: Work of art I once prepared

Past

Creation

Make

Production

Step-by-Step Solution

Step 1 – Find the Indicator

The word Prepared is the anagram indicator.

Step 2 – Identify the Letters

The letters to be rearranged are I ONCE.

Step 3 – Rearrange the Letters

I ONCE → CREATION

Step 4 – Verify the Definition

The definition is "Work of art." A Creation is a work of art.

Final Answer: CREATION 

Common Mistakes

Ignoring the anagram indicator.

Rearranging the wrong letters.

Forgetting to check the answer length.

Choosing an answer that matches the definition but not the wordplay.

Key Points to Remember

Every anagram clue contains letters that must be rearranged.

Always identify the anagram indicator first.

Rearrange only the specified letters.

The final answer must satisfy both the definition and the wordplay.

Always verify the answer length before selecting the final answer.

BSEB Competitiion Tip

Anagram clues are among the most frequently asked clue types in cryptic crossword competitions. Whenever you see words like mixed, wild, prepared, confused, broken, or jumbled, first check whether the nearby letters can be rearranged to form the correct answer.

Chapter: 3.1

Acrostic Clue or (Initial Letters) clue



What is an Acrostic Clue?

An Acrostic Clue, also known as an Initial Letters Clue, is a clue in which the answer is formed by taking the first letter of selected words.

To help the solver recognize an acrostic clue, the clue usually contains an indicator

word that tells you to use the first or initial letters of the words.

Example:

First Creature offers white liquid → Cow

The answer is formed by taking the first letter of each selected word.

How to Identify an Acrostic Clue

When solving a cryptic clue, look for words that suggest taking the first or initial letters. These words are known as Acrostic Indicators.

Common Acrostic Indicators

At First

First

Initially

Initial

To Begin With

First Letters

Starts Of

Opening

Leading

Heads Of

Tip: An indicator usually appears immediately before or after the words whose first letters need to be selected.

How to Solve an Acrostic Clue

Follow these four simple steps:

Step 1: Find the Acrostic Indicator.

Step 2: Identify the words whose first letters must be taken.

Step 3: Take the first letter of each selected word to form a meaningful word.

Step 4: Verify that the new word matches both the definition and the required answer length.

Solved Example

Sums Up All Denominators Directly Setting
At First

Plus

Total

Minus

Adds

Step-by-Step Solution

Step 1 – Find the Indicator

The words At First indicate that we need to take the first letters.

Step 2 – Identify the Words

The relevant words are:

All

Denominators

Directly

Setting

Step 3 – Take the First Letters

$A + D + D + S = \text{ADDS}$

Step 4 – Verify the Definition

The definition is "Sums Up." The word **ADDS** means "Sums Up," so it satisfies the definition perfectly.

Final Answer: **ADDS** 

Common Mistakes

Ignoring the acrostic indicator.

Taking letters from the wrong words.

Taking complete words instead of only the first letters.

Forgetting to verify the definition.

Ignoring the required answer length.

Key Points to Remember

Every acrostic clue uses the first letters of selected words.

Always identify the acrostic indicator first.

Take only the specified first letters.

The final answer must satisfy both the definition and the wordplay.

Always verify the answer length before selecting the final answer.

BSEB Exam Tip

Acrostic clues are usually easy to identify because of indicator words such as at first, first, initially, and initial. Whenever you spot these words, immediately check whether the first letters of the nearby words form one of the given answer options. This simple habit can help you solve acrostic clues quickly and accurately.

Chapter: 3.2

Charade clue



What is a Charade Clue?

A Charade Clue is one of the most common clue types in cryptic crosswords. In this type of clue, the answer is obtained by combining or relating two or more words, meanings, abbreviations, or letter groups.

Unlike an Anagram Clue, the letters are not rearranged. Instead, each part of the clue contributes to the final answer through a logical connection.

Example:

Book part getting torn

Here, PA from part and GE from getting makes PAGE which is related to book.

How to Identify a Charade Clue

When solving a cryptic clue, try breaking the clue into two or more meaningful parts. Each part usually gives a word, meaning, abbreviation, or letter group that contributes to the final answer.

Unlike some other clue types, Charade clues often do not have a fixed indicator word. The clue itself suggests how the different parts relate to each other.

Common Joining Words

And

With

Plus

After

Before

Followed by

Next to

Along with

Tip: If the clue can be divided into separate meaningful parts that together lead to the answer, it is likely a Charade Clue.

How to Solve a Charade Clue

Follow these four simple steps:

Step 1: Divide the clue into meaningful parts.

Step 2: Find the meaning, abbreviation, or letter group represented by each part.

Step 3: Combine or relate these parts logically to form the answer.

Step 4: Verify that the answer matches both the definition and the required answer length.

Solved Example

Honest love to write

Affection

Sincerity

Open

Novel

Step-by-Step Solution

Step 1 – Divide the Clue

The clue can be divided into two parts:

Honest

Love to write

Step 2 – Find the Meaning of Each Part

Honest → Open

Love to write → Pen

Step 3 – Combine the Parts

The word PEN is an essential part of the word OPEN, leading us to the answer OPEN.

Step 4 – Verify the Definition

The definition is "Honest." The word Open means honest, frank, and truthful.

Final Answer: OPEN 

Common Mistakes

Trying to rearrange letters instead of combining meanings.

Ignoring abbreviations or alternative meanings.

Assuming every clue has an indicator word.

Forgetting to verify the definition.

Ignoring the required answer length.

Key Points to Remember

Charade clues are solved by combining or relating different parts of the clue.

The letters are not rearranged.

Solve each part separately before connecting them.

The final answer must satisfy both the definition and the wordplay.

Always verify the answer length before selecting the final answer.

BSEB Exam Tip

In BSEB Cryptic Crossword competitions, Charade clues often rely on simple meanings, common abbreviations, and logical word relationships rather than direct letter manipulation. Break the clue into smaller parts, solve each part individually, and then connect them logically to arrive at the correct answer.

Thank You!!

Thank you for reading this book.

I hope it helped you understand cryptic crossword clues more clearly and improve your solving skills.

"The more cryptic clues you solve, the less cryptic they become."

Keep practicing, stay curious, and enjoy every puzzle.

A Note to Readers

Every effort has been made to ensure the accuracy of the content in this book.

However, mistakes or omissions may still exist. If you find any errors, please treat them as unintentional.

This book is designed as a general learning resource for understanding cryptic crossword clue types and solving techniques. While it may be helpful for BSEB Cryptic Crossword preparation, it has not been created specifically for BSEB examinations or competitions and has no official connection, affiliation, or

endorsement from BSEB or any government organization.

Thank you once again for your support.

Happy Solving!

— Abhijeet Shrivastava